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Design Thinking

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The Future of Education for the Third World

I'm from Karakalpakstan, an autonomous country within Uzbekistan, Central Asia. This background set me up for project 5, because I wanted to look at education and access to learning from a third-world perspective. At Dartmouth, I'm always amazed by how much access we have in terms of technologies (almost every classroom has a projector and a computer, flushable toilets, automated hand-scanning in a dining hall etc.) and internet. I did not want to look at the future of education from a U.S. perspective, because here it is a lot more developed and almost everyone has some sort of device. As my country shares borders with Turkmenistan (it's believed to be "North Korea" of Central Asia, because it's often a closed country and doesn't release data about its educational growth) and Afghanistan (under the Taliban rule, girls over 12 are not allowed to go to school). Having grown up with stories of displacement and refugees, I was passionate about at least innovating an idea that can elevate learning for girls in developing countries. We had to step back and think about an idea that's not dependent on having a phone or internet connection.

My most favorite part of the process was shooting the video. We went to Wheeler, a dorm where Jack and Sienna live, and shot most parts of it. Interestingly, we made up the whole story on the spot. During the process, as expected, we mistakenly laughed or forgot what we were going to say. It was a lot of fun!

Each one of us had some skill that we could bring to the table, which was one of the advantages of working on a team. For example, I wanted to explore Photoshop deeper and wanted to design the project idea on it for the second crit session, and took the responsibility. Sienna is really good at drawing, and she drew most of the storyboards. Jack apparently had prior experience in making various video edits, so he completely took that responsibility.

One difficulty we encountered was, things came up and we couldn't meet together as a team frequently, which rushed us somehow at the end. Next time, it can be suggested to meet at least online as a team, and it doesn't always have to be in-person.

Three learnings I would like to take away from this: (1) when innovating, think about people in other countries and what their conditions are, (2) a future user won't always be from my background and how can I make my product to be universally applicable?, (3) how can I communicate my idea without needing to create a physical prototype of it?

I think everyone tried to contribute equally, and I would give 33.33% to each one of us. In our team contract, we set clear communication and equal distribution of labour as our main goals. Jack fully edited the video, helped with the presentation and wrote on the whiteboard, Sienna drew the storyboards and also contributed to some parts of the presentation, and I created the Photoshop designs and also contributed to the slide content and design. Sienna had time some constraints to prepare for the presentation, but she wanted to contribute as best as she could.